satin. He observes ‘the base and disgusting adulation which is invariably witnessed there’ and ‘the vice of flattery [that] pervades all ranks’. He describes the luxurious but cloistered lives of women in the Seraglio. Whereas Shah Jahan invited singing and dancing girls there, ‘often detained them the whole night, and amused himself with their antics and follies’, Aurangzeb doesn’t do so. Bernier writes that Aurangzeb ‘is more serious than his father’ and ‘anxious to appear a true Musulman’. His ‘extremely liberal’ and erudite brother Dara Shikoh, who translated the Upanishads into Persian, had called him a ‘Nemazi’, or ‘“that Bigot,” that ever-prayerful one’. But Dara too had many flaws. Bernier thinks he was ‘very irascible; apt to menace; abusive and insulting even to the greatest Omrahs’ and undervalued ‘the opinions of the wisest counsellors’. Whereas Aurangzeb possessed ‘a sounder judgment, and was more skilful in selecting for confidants such persons as were best qualified to serve him with faithfulness and ability’ and ‘whose talents for government [his father] always entertained a high opinion’.

The common man’s life, however, is very different. ‘In Dehli there is no middle state. A man must either be of the highest rank or live miserably.’ In Paris, ‘seven or eight out of ten individuals seen in the streets are tolerably well clad, and have a certain air of respectability; but in Dehli, for two or three who wear decent apparel, there [are] seven or eight poor, ragged, and miserable beings’. All in all, he tells his friend, ‘I may indeed say, without partiality, and after making every allowance for the beauty of Dehli, Agra, and Constantinople, that Paris is the finest, the richest, and altogether the first city in the world.’

Among the things he misses from home is bread. Bakers ‘are numerous,’ he writes, ‘but the ovens are unlike our own, and very defective. The bread, therefore, is neither well made nor properly baked.’ Liquor is forbidden, ‘equally by the Gentile and Mahometan law’, but secretly consumed. Wine is rare, and those imported by the Dutch ‘are so dear that, as we say at home, the taste is destroyed by the cost’. Only a few Christians ‘dare openly to drink’ a tipple called Arac, which is ‘harsh and burning’.

On the Social and Economic Conditions of ‘Hindoustan’